

Reading the Interpretive *Gap*

reflection on what you expect, and what the AI returns to us

A unit in critical AI literacy · M.A. in Artificial Intelligence Innovation · Marty Miller



NOT Neutral Tool NOT Autonomous Force

Two absolute positions, and the relational view this unit takes between them

Instrumentalism

The tool is neutral

A means and nothing more. It does nothing until I pick it up and carries no values of its own. The agency is all mine, so everything depends on how I use it. (i.e., Feenberg*)

Postphenomenology

The tool mediates

Never neutral and never in charge. It amplifies some of what I notice and reduces the rest, so agency is shared between me, the tool, and the world (i.e. Ihde and Verbeek).

Determinism

The tool is autonomous

A force with its own logic, pushing from outside. The technology sets the direction, and we mostly adjust to where it is taking us. (i.e. McLuhan*)

The gap between what you expect and what the AI returns reveals how the tool shaped what you saw.

**Feenberg and McLuhan are cited here as critics who name these positions, not as advocates of them.*

Four Ways a Technology Sits With Us

After Don Ihde's postphenomenology - (*Technology and the Lifeworld*, 1990)

Embodiment



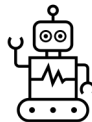
glasses. I look through the tool and it shapes what I see, and I stop noticing the tool is there.

Hermeneutic



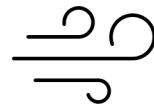
wristwatch, I read the tool's output like an instrument I have to interpret.

Alterity



automated teller/chatbot, I treat the tool as another party I am in dialogue with.

Background



centralized air-conditioning, the tool runs (but not sensed) to shape collective experience.

Coaching Agent build: One Tool, Each Relation

Making it (v1)

Hermeneutic

I interpret and shape what the coach should be.

It talks back (v2)

Alterity

It questions my reading as a second party, not a mirror.

It reads the field (v3)

Background

It grounds in the readings and names how the model leans.

Using it over time

Embodiment

I look through it and stop noticing the coach's own interpretive lens, until the gap between my expectation and result reveals it.

<https://github.com/silosmart/ai-innovation-workspace/>



open ACTIVITIES.md

What We Will Actually Do

*The **9 Stage arc** of this unit will work on your own/supplied images after the coach is built*

Stages 1-2

Set up

Build your coaching agent, then open your own image archive, then prompt your own understanding before the AI analyzes it.

Stages 3-5

Direct

Ask the model to name your kinds/types of screenshots by what's on the phone screen. Keep every prompt, then check which you can point to and which it guessed at. Then run a second agent that sorts them by why you saved each one (i.e., the intention behind keeping it).

Stages 6-7

Make/compare

Turn the model's reading of your archive into a picture, compare that image to your own pictures, then edit it by hand online to expose what the tool invented beyond your flat image.

Stages 8-9

Consolidate/reflect

Write one master prompt that carries your own position and the two disagreeing readings forward for further use. Then read back over your whole prompt trail to aid reflective writing. Then submit all content.

Primary Idea

There is a **gap** between what I expect an AI to say about an image and what it actually says.

That gap is where the learning happens, as it can afford reflection on how to adjust the prompting process, and dual reflections on personal habits of remembering and the non-neutrality of the model.

**Video Demo of Stage 3: "Reading the Archive" (the model reads your screenshots)*

What Aids Reflection Afterward

What you keep, and the questions it lets you answer

What you keep and submit

All media/content created

Your work created during all demo exercises.

The prompt proof tree

Every prompt and revision, kept automatically as you work.

The reflection

Your written account of the experience based upon the four reflective criteria to the right.

What the reflection answers

1. What did I expect, and what surprised me.
2. What does that pattern reveal about my habits of reading.
3. When did my attention shift between the tool and what I wanted to make through it.
4. What stayed unexplained no matter how I probed.

Everything you noticed about the model gets sorted in three ways:

- *what you can prove from your saved prompts*
- *what you are only assuming*
- *what you do not know*

****Video Demo of Stage 9: "Reading the Trail" (the coach reads your prompt trail back to you)***

Essential Authors + Topics for This Unit

- IHDE —————> the four human-technology relations
- VERBEEK —————> the moral mediation of technology
- WILTSE —————> transparency and opacity
- FROSH —————> the multimodal networked image
- LIPTON —————> the limits of model interpretability

Unit Bibliography

The full reading list, with the chapters we draw on

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